

from convention, largely because they regard such departures as a criticism of themselves.

"They will pardon much unconventionality in a man who has enough jollity and friendliness to make it clear... that he is not engaged in criticizing him.

"But, there is no point in deliberately flouting public opinion.

"Fear of public opinion, like every other form of fear, is oppressive and stunts growth. . . . The only ultimate cure for this evil is however an increase of toleration on the part of the public. The best way to increase toleration is to multiply the number of individuals who enjoy happiness and do not therefore find their chief pleasure in the infliction of pain upon their fellow men."

B.S., San Leandro, Calif.

* * * * *

"Please find enclosed a money order for \$2.00. I should like to receive as many of your back issues as that amount will cover. In the event \$2.00 is in excess of the cost of six issues - well, fine. Those few cents may stand as a mere downpayment toward sizeable (for me, that is) donations I know already that I shall be sending to you.

"I hope you are somewhat interested in off-the-top-of-the-head reactions from across the country because I would like to offer a few by way of the following:

"(1) I'm glad as heck that you exist. You are obviously serious people and I feel that women, without wishing to foster any strict separatist notions, homo or hetero, indeed have a need for their own publications and organizations. Our problems, our experiences as women are profoundly unique as compared to the other half of the human race. Women, like other oppressed groups of one kind or another, have particularly had to pay a price for the intellectual impoverishment that the second class status imposed on us for centuries created and sustained. Thus, I feel that THE LADDER is a fine, elementary step in a rewarding direction.

"(2) Rightly or wrongly (in view of some of the thought provoking discussions I have seen elsewhere in a homosexual publication) I could not help but be encouraged and relieved by one of the almost subsidiary points under Point I of your declaration of purpose, '(to advocate) a mode of behaviour and dress acceptable to society'. As one raised in a cultural experience (I am a Negro) where those within were and are forever lecturing to their fellows about how to appear acceptable to the dominant social group, I know something about the shallowness of such a view as an end in itself.

"The most splendid argument is simple and to the point, Ralph Bunche, with all his clean fingernails, degrees, and, of course, undeniable service to the human race, could still be insulted, denied a hotel room or meal in many parts of our country. (Not to mention the possibility of being lynched on a lonely Georgia road for perhaps having demanded a glass of water in the wrong place.)

"What ought to be clear is that one is oppressed or discriminated against because one is different, not 'wrong' or 'bad' somehow. This is perhaps the bitterest of the entire pill. HOWEVER, as a matter of facility, of expediency, one has to take a critical view of revolutionary attitudes which in spite of the BASIC truth I have mentioned above, may tend to aggravate the problems of a group.

"I have long since passed that period when I felt personal discomfort at the sight of an ill-dressed or illiterate Negro. Social awareness has taught me where to lay the blame. Someday, I expect, the 'discreet' Lesbian will not turn her head on the streets at the sight of the 'butch' strolling hand in hand with her friend in their trousers and definitive haircuts. But for the moment, it still disturbs. It creates an impossible area for discussion with one's most enlightened (to use a hopeful term) heterosexual friends. Thus, I agree with the inclusion of that point in your declaration to the degree of wanting to comment on it.

"(3) I am impressed by the general tone of your articles. The most serious fault being at this juncture that there simply is too little.

"(4) Would it be presumptuous or far-fetched to suggest

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NOT appeal to readers seeking sensationalism.



Mattachine **REVIEW**

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that you try for some overseas communications? One hears
so much of publications and organizations devoted to homo-
sexuality and homosexuals in Europe; but as far as I can
gather these seem to lean heavily toward male questions
and interests."

"Just a little afterthought: considering Mattachine;
Bilitis, ONE; all seem to be cropping up on the West Coast
rather than here where a vigorous and active gay set almost
bump one another off the streets - what is it in the air
out there? Pioneers still? Or a tougher circumstance
which inspires battle? Would like to hear speculation,
light-hearted or otherwise."

L.H.N., New York, N.Y.